



No rhythm, no crowds, no traction

A plan to integrate the Super Cup into the regular ISL season was quietly shelved. "We thought it could be done in the FA Cup style," said AIFF Deputy Secretary M. Satyanarayan. "But it was difficult to schedule midweek games."

The fallback was far from ideal. The competition returned just two weeks after the ISL ended, squeezing 14 games into 13 days. Early kick-offs under Bhubaneswar's punishing sun only made things worse. Most stadium seats stayed empty.

Fatigue became a running theme. Teams sent depleted squads, rested key players, and played it safe. Mumbai City FC head coach Petr Kratky summed it up after their

semifinal exit against JFC: "If you play every three days in this kind of climate, the players will get tired. We have had enough injuries already."

Moreover, the decision to restrict the tournament to a single venue over a short span deprived teams — especially lower division sides like Inter Kashi and Gokulam Kerala — of the opportunity to host matches and engage their local fanbases.

Such a model would not only boost ticket numbers but also make results like Kashi's one-off win in this tournament over ISL giant Bengaluru FC in the first round more memorable, highlighting the beauty and unpredictability of cup football.

However, according to Satyanarayan, Odisha was granted

Vital cogs: FC Goa's foreign contingent scored nine of its 11 goals. Borja (centre) and Iker led the way with four each, while Carl McHugh scored one. PICS: BISWARANJAN ROUT

the rights to host the competition because of its intent to foster a football culture in the state. "We can't have every game in West Bengal and Kerala, where we know the crowds will come."

"In other states, you have to start somewhere," he explained.

Uneven field, predictable finish

Unlike the ISL (which allows four), the Super Cup allowed six foreigners per team on the pitch. Unsurprisingly, the two teams that went all-in — FCG and JFC — reached the final.

The biggest surprise came from the ISL Shield and Cup champion Mohun Bagan Super Giant, which decided to relieve all of its overseas stars except one from the regular season and send a reserve squad for an "exposure trip", in the words of its stand-in coach Bastab Roy.

While the youngsters held their mettle against Kerala Blasters FC in the quarters, they were quickly

Unlike the ISL (which allows four), the Super Cup allowed six foreigners per team on the pitch. Unsurprisingly, the two teams that went all-in — FCG and JFC — reached the final.